Heart Healthy Diet for South Asians

What is a heart healthy diet?

A heart healthy diet lowers the risk of developing heart disease. It consists of many plant-based foods, lean protein and low-fat dairy foods. This diet limits refined carbohydrates, sugar, salt and and fat.

Foods to Choose!

- **Vegetables and Fruits:** leafy greens (spinach, cabbage, kale), avocados, apples, berries
- **Whole grains:** brown rice, whole-wheat flour or ragi
- **Plant-based proteins:** tofu, chickpeas, black-eyed beans
- **Lean proteins:** fish, chicken



Why are South Asians at a greater risk of Heart Disease?

South Asians **(India, Pakistan, Bangladesh)** are more likely to store belly fat (visceral fat) and are often genetically predisposed to developing diabetes and high cholesterol. These factors together increase the likelihood of developing heart disease.

Foods to Limit!

- **Refined Carbs:** white rice, white flour, chapattis
- **Processed Sugar** in desserts and drinks
- **Ghee, Coconut Oil, Palm Oil**
- **Salty foods**

Easy Switches

- Substitute full-fat Paneer with extra-firm tofu
- Enjoy fruit chaat for dessert after meals
- Replace white flour with whole-wheat flour for chapattis
- Opt for tarka or air-frying instead of frying foods in oil

References:
- https://mynutriweb.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/10/Untitled-700-x-700-px.pdf
- https://www.lipid.org/sites/default/files/heart_healthy_eating_south_asian_style.pdf